fact that I completed seven years of service without a state commission of inquiry, in a country that is inundated with them.

The CIA—Our Big Sister

The red light of the intercom on my desk lit up. It was the director of the Mossad, Nahum Admoni, on the line. “Do you have a few minutes?” he asked, and when I answered yes, he said, “Come down to my office.”

The year was 1987. I was deputy director of the Mossad and head of the Headquarters Division. I was in my office, two floors above the director’s bureau. I went down the stairs, and the secretary opened the door for me.

Had I been given ten chances to guess which people I was about to meet, I still would not have been able to guess. Sitting in the office with Nahum were four men whom I easily identified as Americans. Nahum introduced me to them, giving my full name and title. Then- CIA director and former federal judge William Webster and his deputy director of operations, Clair George, introduced themselves.

It was my first meeting with the CIA. The rumor, which may or may not have been true, was that when they returned to the United States a CIA officer was appointed to investigate why the Central Intelligence Agency of the United States had not known about me, the number two man in the Mossad, until the meeting I described above. The Americans should indeed have known about me, but apparently there is no perfect intelligence organization.

In 1979, the Revolutionary Guards took over the US embassy in Tehran, seized hostages, and got hold of the embassy’s information archive. Later, and in a roundabout way, we received a document from the archives of the CIA office in Tehran that had been released by the Iranians as part of a smear campaign against the Americans in general and the CIA in particular. The document we received was a report by a CIA agent in Tehran from late January 1966 describing a young Israeli couple that had arrived in Tehran in mid-January and would drive around the city in a little Triumph. The couple in question was my wife Yael and myself. In those days, sophisticated “link analysis” software did not yet exist, and apparently the CIA did not cross-check the information.

My first direct acquaintance with America was in the early 1980s, on the eve of my first appointment as a Mossad division head. It was a one-time